



Evaluating AI Outputs

Parsons Party
September 3, 2026



To Cover

- TRACES checklist
- Good and bad examples
- Evaluating summaries
- Evaluating prompts
- Building an even better prompt



TRACES

Traceable

Can I see where each claim came from?

Reasonable

Does this actually make sense to me?

Auditable

Could I actually check it against the source and do the calculations myself, if needed?

Caveated

Are gaps (caveats) explicitly stated?

Exact

Which population, which time window, what's in/out?

Safe

Is it safe to share? Or would that violate privacy? Is there PII in the summary?



Traceable

Can I see where each claim came from?

BAD

“RSVPs are up significantly.”

BETTER

“RSVPs are up significantly (per Action Network).”



Reasonable

Does this actually make sense to me?

BAD

“Attendance hit 218% of RSVPs — huge turnout.”

BETTER

“392 attended vs 412 RSVPs — 95% show rate.” (high but plausible)



Auditable

Could I actually check it against the source and do the calculations myself, if needed?

BAD

“Per the March export, RSVPs grew.”

BETTER

“RSVPs grew. (Sum rsvp_count March 2-8 → 412.)”



Caveated

Are gaps (caveats) explicitly stated?

BAD

“Regional totals below.”
(Three days missing, never mentioned.)

BETTER

“Regional totals below. Southeast missing 3 of 7 days — treat regional ranking as provisional.”



Exact

Which population, which time window, what's in/out?

BAD

“Volunteer signups are trending up this spring.”

BETTER

“Event RSVPs only, Mar 2–8, 2026, all regions; excludes canceled events.”



Safe

Is it safe to share? Or would that violate privacy? Is there PII in the summary?

BAD

“Average of 6 shifts per volunteer.
Maximum: Jane Smith, Washington
DC - 18 shifts.”

BETTER

“Average of 6 shifts per volunteer,
with a maximum of 18 shifts.”

Reasonable vs auditable

Reasonable = what you catch by reading.

Auditable = what you catch by checking.

Wrong numbers often look reasonable. Auditable allows you to check that they're actually correct.

Traceable vs Auditable

Traceable cites a source. Auditable gives you specific directions.

Traceable: “(Event Report, March 2022)”

Auditable: “Event Report, March 22 - Appendix 1 (events.csv) - re-sum
rsvp_count column to confirm”

(Do you need Traceable if you have Auditable? Maybe not... maybe it's just
RACES. ^_(ツ)_/ ^)

Sample Summaries

Framing question:

“How did the Clean Water Now petition program do June 1–7, 2026?”

```

1  date,connector,runs_attempted,runs_succeeded,rows_loaded,avg_duration_s,last_error_class,data_as_of
2  2026-08-17,action_network,24,24,18432,42,,2026-08-25
3  2026-08-17,mobilize,24,23,3110,55,TimeoutError,2026-08-25
4  2026-08-17,actblue,24,24,942,31,,2026-08-25
5  2026-08-18,action_network,24,24,17980,44,,2026-08-25
6  2026-08-18,mobilize,24,24,3044,53,,2026-08-25
7  2026-08-18,actblue,24,24,1012,30,,2026-08-25
8  2026-08-19,action_network,24,22,16110,61,ConnectionResetError,2026-08-25
9  2026-08-19,mobilize,24,24,0,29,,2026-08-25
10 2026-08-19,actblue,24,24,988,32,,2026-08-25
11 2026-08-20,action_network,24,24,18205,43,,2026-08-25
12 2026-08-20,mobilize,24,24,2998,54,,2026-08-25
13 2026-08-20,actblue,24,20,760,88,HTTPError429,2026-08-25
14 2026-08-21,action_network,24,24,19340,45,,2026-08-25
15 2026-08-21,mobilize,24,24,3260,52,,2026-08-25
16 2026-08-21,actblue,24,24,1105,33,,2026-08-25
17 2026-08-22,action_network,24,24,12010,40,,2026-08-25
18 2026-08-22,mobilize,24,24,1420,49,,2026-08-25
19 2026-08-22,actblue,24,24,410,28,,2026-08-25
20 2026-08-23,action_network,24,24,11450,39,,2026-08-25
21 2026-08-23,mobilize,24,24,1298,48,,2026-08-25
22 2026-08-23,actblue,24,24,388,27,,2026-08-25

```

```

1  date,day_of_week,petition_signups,actions_taken,email_sends,email_opens,new_subscribers,sync_status,
   data_as_of
2  2026-05-25,Mon,104,130,12100,2880,88,ok,2026-06-09
3  2026-05-26,Tue,91,115,11600,2610,71,ok,2026-06-09
4  2026-05-27,Wed,88,109,11900,2701,69,ok,2026-06-09
5  2026-05-28,Thu,97,118,12000,2760,77,ok,2026-06-09
6  2026-05-29,Fri,132,160,13400,3216,102,ok,2026-06-09
7  2026-05-30,Sat,70,84,0,0,48,ok,2026-06-09
8  2026-05-31,Sun,58,66,0,0,39,ok,2026-06-09
9  2026-06-01,Mon,118,143,12400,2914,96,ok,2026-06-09
10 2026-06-02,Tue,96,121,11850,2559,74,ok,2026-06-09
11 2026-06-03,Wed,0,0,0,0,0,failed,2026-06-09
12 2026-06-04,Thu,0,0,0,0,0,failed,2026-06-09
13 2026-06-05,Fri,412,489,24600,6051,318,ok,2026-06-09
14 2026-06-06,Sat,74,88,0,0,51,ok,2026-06-09
15 2026-06-07,Sun,61,70,0,0,43,ok,2026-06-09

```

Overall
shape of
data (note
errors and
failures)

See Github
repo for
actual
datasets

Summary A



Weekly Summary: Petition Engagement (May 25–June 7, 2026)

Overview — Two weeks of daily engagement data show strong weekday performance with predictable weekend dips. Total petition signups reached 1,391, with 1,693 actions taken and 1,076 new subscribers. Email volume totaled 109,850 sends and 25,691 opens (~23% open rate on send days).

Week 1 (May 25–31) — Signups averaged ~91/day on weekdays, peaking Friday (132). Weekend signups dropped to 70 (Sat) and 58 (Sun), with no email sends on weekends—a consistent pattern. New subscribers totaled 494 for the week.

Week 2 (June 1–7) — June 3–4 recorded sync failures with zero data captured; treat those days as missing, not zero activity. Excluding those gaps, the week ended strong: Friday June 5 showed a major spike (412 signups, 489 actions, 24,600 email sends)—likely reflecting catch-up from the outage plus normal Friday volume. Week 2 added 582 new subscribers.

Issues & Recommendations

1. **Data integrity:** Two consecutive failed sync days (June 3–4) undermine week-over-week comparisons. Investigate sync pipeline before the next reporting cycle.
2. **Weekend gap:** No email sends Sat/Sun; confirm this is intentional and whether weekend-only signups are being nurtured on Monday.
3. **Friday effect:** Both Fridays were top performers; consider scheduling high-impact campaigns accordingly.

All successful records are marked `data_as_of: 2026-06-09`.

Summary B

Petition & engagement summary — June 1–7, 2026

Population: Daily program totals in the CSV (one row per calendar day). All figures below are sums or rates across 2026-06-01 through 2026-06-07 unless noted.

Petition signups (petition_signups, Jun 1–7): 761 total. Peak day: 412 on Fri Jun 5. Wed–Thu show 0 with sync_status = failed; those days may be incomplete, not zero activity.

Actions taken (actions_taken, Jun 1–7): 911 total. Fri Jun 5: 489; other synced weekdays ranged 121–143.

Email volume & engagement (email_sends / email_opens, Jun 1–7): 48,850 sends and 11,524 opens on days with sends (Mon, Tue, Fri only). Open rate: 23.6% (opens ÷ sends). Sat–Sun rows show 0 sends/opens (weekend pattern in file).

List growth (new_subscribers, Jun 1–7): 582 new subscribers. Fri Jun 5: 318; failed-sync days: 0 recorded.

Data quality (sync_status, Jun 1–7): 5 of 7 days synced ok; Jun 3–4 failed. Entire file is stamped data_as_of 2026-06-09.

Takeaway: Strong Fri spike drives the week; Wed–Thu gaps limit confidence in full-week totals. Treat 761 signups / 911 actions / 582 subscribers as a lower bound until failed days are backfilled.

Summary C



Weekly metrics note — petition & engagement (June 1–7, 2026)

Population: Daily petition/engagement aggregates in the attached file (date, petition_signups, actions_taken, email_sends, email_opens, new_subscribers, sync_status). In scope: 7 rows, date 2026-06-01 through 2026-06-07. Out of scope: May 25–31; individual records; any source beyond this extract.

Top line (full week, all 7 days):

- 761 petition signups (petition_signups, sum Jun 1–7)
- 911 actions taken (actions_taken, sum Jun 1–7)
- 48,850 email sends and 11,524 opens (email_sends / email_opens, sum Jun 1–7)
- 582 new subscribers (new_subscribers, sum Jun 1–7)

Caveats: Jun 3–4 show sync_status=failed with all metrics at 0—treat as missing, not confirmed zero activity. All rows show data_as_of=2026-06-09 (possible backfill). Jun 6–7 show 0 email sends/opens (weekend pattern in-file; not necessarily a sync failure).

Cross-check / flags: Failed days may understate the week. Jun 5 (Fri) drove 412 signups (54% of the week's total)—a sharp jump vs other days (e.g., Jun 1: 118; Jun 2: 96). Weekday email open rate: $11,524 \div 48,850 \approx 23.6\%$ (opens/sends for Jun 1–2 and Jun 5 only; weekends excluded).

Spot-checks: (1) Sum petition_signups Jun 1–7 → 761. (2) Count sync_status=failed in range → 2 rows. (3) $911 \div 761 \approx 1.20$ actions per signup (full week; includes failed-day zeros).

Aggregates only; no individual identifiers. Figures describe reported syncs, not verified ground truth for failed days.

Debrief

- Same model
- Same CSV (with planted backfill issue)
- Same 250-word cap
- Model: composer-2.5-fast, captured 2026-08-28



(Planted backfill issue)

date	signups	actions	sync
Jun 1 Mon	118	143	ok
Jun 2 Tue	96	121	ok
Jun 3 Wed	0	0	failed
Jun 4 Thu	0	0	failed
Jun 5 Fri	412	489	ok
Jun 6 Sat	74	88	ok
Jun 7 Sun	61	70	ok

Summary A Prompt (minimal)



PROMPT

Write a weekly summary
of this CSV for the
program director.

Keep it under 250 words.

Weekly Summary: Petition Engagement (May 25–June 7, 2026)

Overview — Two weeks of daily engagement data show strong weekday performance with predictable weekend dips. Total petition signups reached 1,391, with 1,693 actions taken and 1,076 new subscribers. Email volume totaled 109,850 sends and 25,691 opens (~23% open rate on send days).

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Issues & Recommendations

1. Data integrity: Two consecutive failed sync days (June 3–4) undermine week-over-week comparisons. Investigate sync pipeline before the next reporting cycle.
2. Weekend gap: No email sends Sat/Sun; confirm this is intentional and whether weekend-only signups are being nurtured on Monday.
3. Friday effect: Both Fridays were top performers; consider scheduling high-impact campaigns accordingly.

All successful records are marked data_as_of: 2026-06-09.

Summary A Prompt (minimal)

Issues

1,391 two-week signups → actual 1,401. Looks reasonable, but if you audit it, it's incorrect.

91/day on weekdays → weekday average is actually 102. Model confused weekday and all days. That's "exact" - did we define our terms and qualifications right?

"Friday effect" → model caught that Friday day was backfilled and unreliable, but didn't flag that in its recommendations.

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2. Weekend gap: No email sends Sat/Sun; confirm this is intentional and whether weekend-only signups are being nurtured on Monday.
3. Friday effect: **Both Fridays were top performers; consider scheduling high-impact campaigns accordingly.**

All successful records are marked data_as_of: 2026-06-09.

Summary B Prompt (name your sources)



PROMPT

Summarize petition and engagement performance for the program director for June 1-7, 2026. Use only the attached CSV. For each statistic, name the source column and the date range it covers. State the exact population the numbers describe. Keep it under 250 words.

Every number in the summary is correct.

Petition & engagement summary — June 1–7, 2026

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Summary B Prompt (name your sources)



ISSUES

All numbers correct.

Correctly flags backfill, but “treat subscribers as lower bound” is incorrect.

Numbers are “traceable” (to their sources) but not “auditable” - if you want to run checks yourself you’d have to infer columns, etc.

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Summary C Prompt (full checklist)



PROMPT

Draft a weekly metrics note for a program director.

Use only the attached CSV. Include:

- Traceable: cite source column + filters/date range
- Reasonable: cross-check figures, flag inconsistencies
- Auditable: 2–3 spot-checks (column sum, count, ratio)
- Caveated: missing data, sync failures, backfill
- Exact: population, date range, what's in/out of scope
- Safe: aggregates only; no individual identifiers

Task: top-line figures for June 1–7, 2026. Keep it under 250 words.

Weekly metrics note — petition & engagement (June 1–7, 2026)

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Summary C Prompt (full checklist)



ISSUES

Flags the sync failure issue as “possible backfill” and flags Fri Jun 5 as “a sharp jump vs other days”. Doesn’t explicitly pull these two facts together but at least doesn’t actively mislead.

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Discussion Questions

- Which summary would you trust most? Which least?
- How could we make our prompts even better?
- What tools could we use, beyond prompting, to create more reliable output?
- How do you balance generating **readable/actionable/usable** reports vs **reliable/correct** ones?